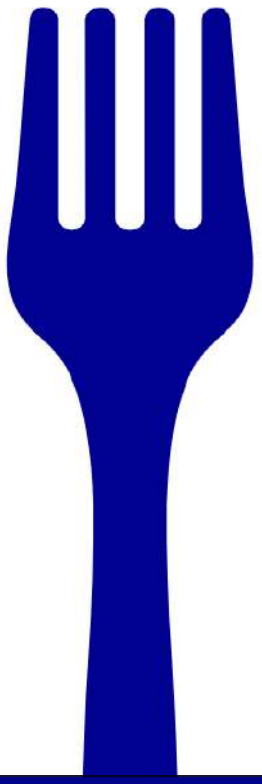
Hack the Fork

HACKATHON PARIS 2026

PARTICIPANT GUIDE



Welcome to Hack the Fork Paris 2026!

Dear participant,

Congratulations, you are part of the Paris edition of Hack the Fork 2026!

From October 30th to November 1st, you will join a multidisciplinary cohort of talented individuals from the Paris-Saclay campus, leading French universities, and industry, with backgrounds in engineering, data science, food science, law, management, and design. Over the course of a weekend, you will identify a problem, develop a concrete solution, and present it to a jury.

This guide brings together everything you need to arrive ready and make the most of these three days on the Saclay plateau: practical organization (locations, times, meals), team composition, what you can prepare in advance and what needs to be done on site, the three challenges of this edition, the rules, the expected deliverables and the exact evaluation grid of the jury.

Before your arrival, take the time to read through this guide and follow the few steps outlined in our email: they will save you valuable time on the day.

The jury doesn't reward the most ambitious project on paper, but the one that proves its claims. Show a concrete result, however modest, and clearly state the limits of your solution. A focused project that works will always be more convincing than a grand but unfulfilled promise.

A question, a doubt? We remain available at any time.

Have a great hackathon everyone!

Warmly,



Morgane Paris

Development Manager - HtF



Inès Mir-Moreaux

Local Leaders Program Manager - HtF



Lucie Avril

Local Leader - AgroParisTech



Hugo Lecoulant

Local Leader - AgroParisTech

Hack the Fork in brief

The food system is at a turning point. Alternative proteins are among the most promising sectors of food technology, but slow research and development is hindering their growth.

Our model rests on three pillars:

Hackathons. We bring together high-calibre students and young professionals (engineers, data scientists, food and management experts, and business professionals) with food technology and foodtech companies to solve real-world industrial challenges. Artificial intelligence (AI) allows us to condense months of research into a single weekend. For our partners, it's also an opportunity to identify talented individuals comfortable with technology.

Pre-incubation. The best prototypes don't necessarily end with hackathons. We help the most promising teams refine them through pre-incubation support and connect them with investors.

Career mentoring. Whether you have a startup project or not, we can help you build a career in alternative proteins. Participating in the hackathon is a gateway to career support if you wish.

Human ingenuity, AI-powered acceleration, and market-driven partnerships: this is how Hack the Fork transforms ideas into businesses that make food sustainable. In 2026, 11 editions are taking place in 8 countries. The Paris edition, hosted by AgroParisTech, carries out this mission with its own ecosystem, partners, and student community.

This hackathon is not an academic exercise: the runner-up of the 2025 edition, **ReaKt**, is currently incubated at Genopole and is well on its way to launching its product on the market.

The hackathon at a glance

Item	Detail
Dates and times	Friday, October 30: 5:30 p.m. to 11 p.m. Saturday, October 31: 8:30 a.m. to 6 p.m. Sunday, November 1st: 8am to 2pm.
Place	Agro Paris-Saclay Campus. Welcome at the Forum, working sessions and pitches in building C1, meals at the Canopée and the Forum. Address: 22 Place de l'Agronomie, 91120 Palaiseau
Your AgroParisTech contacts	• Hugo Lecoulant (+33 6 47 97 48 20) • Lucie Avril (+33 6 10 53 64 94)
Your Hack the Fork contacts	• **Inès Mir-Moreaux (+33 6 77 28 65 30) ines.mir-moreaux@hackthefork.org** • Morgane Paris (+33 6 44 95 54 05) morgane.paris@hackthefork.org
Participants' channel	WhatsApp Link

Logistics

How it runs. The hackathon opens on Friday, October 30th at 5:30 PM and ends on Sunday, November 1st at 2 PM. Saturday is the day you will achieve the bulk of your work.

Getting there. You will be welcomed on the Agro Paris-Saclay campus, at the Forum.

Exact address: 22 Place de l'Agronomie, 91120 Palaiseau.

By public transport (approximately 45 minutes to 1 hour from Paris)

- **RER B** or **RER C** to **Massy-Palaiseau**, then **bus 4606**, towards Saint-Quentin-en-Yvelines or Christ de Saclay, to the **Palaiseau-Campus** stop**.** Please note: on Sundays, train frequencies are reduced and the RER B line may be undergoing maintenance. Check your journey the day before on the Île-de-France Mobilités website and allow extra time.

By car (approximately 25 minutes from Porte d'Orléans)

- Take the **N118**, exit 8 "Jouy-en-Josas Saclay", then follow the **D36 towards Palaiseau.** The campus has a car park, accessible via 41 or 45 Cours Pierre Vasseur.

The event takes place in three locations: the **Forum** for reception and meals, **Building C1** for the amphitheater, the work rooms and the pitches, and the **Canopée** for cocktails.



Welcome. Please present yourself at the Forum reception desk on Friday, October 30th, **between 5:30 pm and 6:00 pm.** For signing in, bring your ID or student card. **Make sure you have filled in the pre-hackathon form sent by email.** It takes 10 minutes and is essential for campus access. It will only be shared with the Hack the Fork global organizing team and is used solely to understand your profile and expectations beforehand.

One email address only. Use the email address you provided when applying to the hackathon. This is the one you will use to log in to your AWS account: do not change it.

Food. All meals and snacks served during the event are 100% plant-based. The following are planned: the cocktail reception and dinner on Friday evening at the Canopée, breakfast and lunch on Saturday, breakfast on Sunday, and the closing cocktail reception on Sunday at noon. If you have allergies, please report them before October 28: ines.mir-moreaux@hackthefork.org.

Nights. The campus closes at 11 p.m. on Fridays and 6 p.m. on Saturdays. Night work takes place off campus, and no accommodation is provided by the organizers: please make arrangements in advance. Before leaving each evening, be sure not to leave any valuables behind.

WiFi. You have received an email with a guide explaining how to connect to the network.

Photos and videos will be taken during the event for the communications of Hack the Fork and AgroParisTech. If you do not wish to appear on social media, please inform the organizing team.

Accessibility and well-being. If you require any special arrangements, please do not hesitate to write to Inès Mir-Moreaux (ines.mir-moreaux@hackthefork.org) or to call her (+33 6 77 28 65 30).

What you need to bring:

- Laptop and charger
- Phone and charger
- USB drive to export your data
- Reusable water bottle
- Notebook and pens
- Comfortable clothes and a warm layer
- Identity document or student card
- Medications and personal belongings

Your schedule

Friday, October 30

Time	Activity	Venue
17h45-18h45	Welcome and team-building time	Forum
18h45-18h55	Words from the student organizers	Building C1
18h55-19h05	Message from the management of AgroParisTech	Building C1
19h05-19h20	Words from the Hack the Fork association	Building C1
19h20-19h35	Recorded presentation by Danone	Building C1
19h35-19h45	Presentation by Plant-Based Universities	Building C1
19h45-20h	Program overview	Building C1
20h00-20h45	Workshop #1 - The Alternative Protein Sector	Building C1

20h45-23h00	Reception and team brainstorming	Canopée and Building C1

Saturday, October 31

Time	Activity	Venue
8h30-9h	Welcome	Forum
9h-9h30	Breakfast	Forum
9h30-10h15	Workshop #2 - AI at the heart of innovation	Building C1
10h15-13h	Teamwork	Building C1
13h-14h	Lunch	Forum
14h-18h	Teamwork	Building C1

Sunday, November 1st

Time	Activity	Venue
8h-8h30	Welcome and breakfast	Forum
8h30-10h	Teamwork, submission of **pitch deck** and of the **project sheet**	Building C1
10h-10h15	Post-hackathon survey	Building C1
10h15-12h	Pitches to the jury	Building C1
12h00-12h30	Back up your projects (USB drive, hard drive, GitHub, etc.)	Building C1
12h30-13h	Awards ceremony and official closing	Building C1
13h-14h15	Closing cocktail / Buffet	Canopée

Your team, and what you can do now

Size. Teams consist of 2 to 5 people. Teams that combine technical, scientific, and business profiles have a significant advantage: the jury's evaluation criteria assess scientific rigor, AI integration, economic viability, impact, and quality of execution. A team with a single profile struggles in four out of five areas.

How teams are formed. A team spreadsheet has been shared with you. It contains the list of participants, their profiles, and those still looking for teammates. This will allow you to identify those you would like to work with and contact them before the event. Teams will meet on-site and begin working on Friday at 8:45 PM, following the first workshop. From 5:45 PM to 6:45 PM, there will be a networking session for participants to connect and identify potential partners.

Challenge selection. On Friday evening, each team chooses one of the three challenges and declares it to the organizers before 11 p.m. Take the time to discuss it together and, if you are unsure, ask a mentor for advice: a well-chosen challenge from the start will save you time.

What you can do before the hackathon starts. Read this guide and the challenge brief, research the sector, meet your teammates, discuss the problem, install your tools, and explore the open resources listed below. It's even recommended: a team that comes prepared with some knowledge of the sector saves several hours compared to others.

Things you cannot do before the start of the hackathon. Build the solution, the code, the model, the prototype, the challenge-specific results, or the final pitch deck. All deliverables must be produced during the event, or the team will be disqualified.

Pre-existing resources must be declared. If you use code, research, datasets, designs, or pre-trained models created before the hackathon, you must declare them when you submit your project. Open-source licenses remain the original ones. A completed project or a patented solution is not eligible.

Before leaving on Sunday. Retrieve and save (to a USB drive, internal/external hard drive, GitHub, etc.) everything your team has produced using AWS tools. Note: accounts will be closed after the event and nothing will be recoverable afterward.

At the end of the hackathon. Each participant will receive a personalized certificate of participation, attesting to their commitment during these three days. Hack the Fork also offers post-hackathon programs for those who wish to continue their project or build an impactful career in food. Access to these programs will be by selection.

Mentoring

Throughout the weekend, mentors from research, industry and entrepreneurship are there to support you: Friday evening, Saturday and Sunday morning.

Their role. They help you define your problem, test your assumptions, compare your idea with industry realities, and refine your presentation. Rather than giving you answers, they ask the right questions: that's what moves a project forward.

What they don't do. They don't write your code, your model, or your presentation: the project remains entirely yours. They also don't participate in the evaluation, which allows you to communicate with them freely, including about your doubts and difficulties.

The challenges of this edition

Before presenting the challenges, here is the context on which the framework is based. The jury is already aware of this: any team that ignores these points will be challenged during the Q&A.

Plant-based proteins: the challenges facing the sector

- **Price, the primary obstacle to adoption.** A plant-based product often costs more than its animal-based equivalent. To reduce this gap, action must be taken across the entire chain, from sourcing to production, and not just by improving recipes.
- **Institutional catering: an underutilized resource.** The law sets several obligations for institutional catering: in school canteens, at least one vegetarian menu per week; in all institutional catering, at least 50% sustainable and high-quality products, including 20% organic products; and since January 2024, at least 60% sustainable and high-quality meat

and fish in public institutional catering. Restaurants serving more than 200 meals per day must also establish a multi-year protein diversification plan. However, there are still few digital tools available to help them develop this plan.

- **Consumer confidence in ultra-processed products.** Consumers increasingly want short and easy-to-read ingredient lists. The challenge is to shorten them without sacrificing texture, taste, or consistency.
- **Dependence on imports.** France currently imports a large portion of the plant-based proteins it consumes. Legumes occupy approximately 4% of its agricultural land, and the goal is to double this share by 2030.
- **Private label brands: a growth engine with limited resources.** They operate in several segments, such as plant-based drinks, but their research and development (R&D) budgets are much lower than those of major brands.

Precision fermentation: the challenges of the sector

- **Scale-up, the first bottleneck.** Moving from laboratory to factory remains slow, costly and risky. To overcome this obstacle, Danone, Michelin and DMC Biotechnologies have invested in a dedicated platform in Clermont-Ferrand, the Biotech Open Platform (BIOP).
- **Few simulation tools are available.** Tools such as digital twins are lacking to predict process performance before launching costly physical trials. Those that do exist are often reserved for large corporations.
- **Very high capital requirements.** Even a start-up that has already received funding needs to raise tens of millions of euros to build a single factory.

Cross-cutting issues

- **Active but underfunded research.** France ranks 7th in Europe for the number of publications on alternative proteins, but its public funding remains far behind that of the United Kingdom and the Netherlands.
- **The transition of agricultural and livestock sectors.** Livestock farmers fear competition that would threaten their incomes, and this fear is hindering political support. Alternative proteins must be developed with farmers, not against them.

Three challenges are proposed. On Friday evening, your team chooses one and responds with a solution where AI plays a real role. Each challenge poses a deliberately broad question: it's up to you to narrow it down to a specific problem for a clearly identified user. Over to you!

Track 1 · Precision fermentation, from the lab to the factory

The problem. In France, research in precision fermentation exists, but industrialization is stalled. Moving from a high-performing strain in the laboratory to profitable production remains slow, expensive, and risky, and every large-scale error is very costly. Accessible simulation tools, such as digital twins, are lacking to predict process performance before investing in physical trials.

The challenge. How can artificial intelligence reduce the risk and cost of scaling up precision fermentation?

Track 2 · Plant-based foods on French plates

The problem. Plant-based products remain more expensive than their animal-based counterparts. Institutional catering, which could significantly influence consumer habits, lacks the tools to

implement its protein diversification obligations under the EGAlim law. Meanwhile, consumers are wary of overly long ingredient lists and processed foods.

The challenge. How can artificial intelligence make plant-based proteins cheaper, simpler, and more present in everyday meals?

Useful open resources:

- Nutritional composition table (ANSES)
- Agribalyse environmental database (ADEME)
- Open Food Facts (ingredient lists and compositions of commercial products)
- Government platform “Ma Cantine” and guides from the National Council for Collective Catering (vegetarian menu, protein diversification plan)

Track 3 · Protein sovereignty, from French fields to the proteins of tomorrow

The problem. Approximately 4% of French agricultural land is dedicated to pulses, with the goal of doubling this share by 2030. For plant-based proteins to replace a growing proportion of animal proteins in the human diet, France needs to produce more pulses for human consumption, rather than livestock feed. This transition is hampered by farmers' and livestock breeders' fears of income loss in a highly competitive market.

The challenge. How can artificial intelligence help farmers and regions to produce the plant-based proteins that the French will eat tomorrow, and to generate income from them?

Useful open resources:

- Agricultural statistics Agreste (Ministry of Agriculture)
- Terres Inovia, the technical institute for oilseeds and pulses

Important: List of topics excluded from the scope of the Hack the Fork hackathon

- Insects.
- Products containing ingredients of animal origin.
- Animal feed. The projects are aimed at direct human consumption: developing plant-based proteins for livestock, including replacing imported soy, is outside the scope.
- Projects without functional demonstration, which show nothing concrete.

A project that falls into these categories is not eligible, regardless of its quality.

If you're unsure, ask a mentor or the organization early. A problem reported on Friday evening costs a few minutes; the same problem discovered on Sunday costs the whole weekend.

Best practices

Regardless of the challenge chosen, the jury looks for the same signs:

- **A specific user** and a decision that your solution helps them make. "Manufacturers" are not a user; "the purchasing manager of a central kitchen" is.
- **A demonstration that works**, even partial. A mockup of screens is not enough.

- **An AI that can be understood.** You can explain simply what it does, what data it relies on, and what its margin of error is. It brings real value to the solution: if we removed it, your project would lose most of its appeal.
- **Traceable data**, by distinguishing what is measured, sourced, assumed or synthetic.
- **Acknowledged limits.** Stating what your model cannot do is a sign of rigor.

A useful test before pitching: what would your solution lose if the AI component were removed? If the answer is "not much", you have a problem with the Authentic Integration of AI dimension.

AI, data and infrastructure

Your AWS account. On Friday, October 30, each team will receive login codes for AWS tools, along with the associated credits, provided as part of our partnership. Access will be sent to the email address you provided on the application form, and you will use this same email address to log in. To get started with the tools, consult the AWS webinar guide and notes (sent via email), as well as this **video**. If you have any problems, contact Morgane Paris on WhatsApp (+33 6 44 95 54 05). Please note that the account will be closed after the hackathon: be sure to save all your work.

AI should carry the solution, not dress it up. A generic conversational layer is insufficient if the same result could be achieved without it. AI must contribute to analysis, prediction, optimization, simulation, computer vision, or evidence gathering.

Approaches that count as real-world use. Predictive modeling, recommendation or ranking, optimization, computer vision, LLM and RAG on credible sources, simulation, segmentation. The list is not exhaustive: what matters is that AI changes the outcome.

Data transparency. Clearly distinguish, in your pitch as well as in your submission, what is measured or sourced, what is based on a hypothesis, and what is synthetic or produced by a model. Synthetic data is permitted for demonstration purposes, provided it is clearly identified: it should never be presented as experimental results.

Sources. Document the datasets, literature, models, and external tools you use. Check the references generated by a language model before displaying them: a fabricated citation is easily detected and negatively impacts the scientific and technical rigor dimension.

Integrity. Fabricating results, falsifying a test, plagiarizing a project, or presenting someone else's work as your own can lead to the team's disqualification.

Pitch and evaluation grid

Format. Each team has 4 minutes for their presentation, followed by 2 minutes of questions from the jury. This time is the same for all teams and must be strictly adhered to: at the end of the 4 minutes, the presentation stops, even if you haven't finished.

Language. The pitches can be presented in French or English, at each team's choice.

All teams follow the same structure: the problem, your solution, a live demonstration or prototype, and then your scaling strategy. We advise you to set aside time for the demonstration: it's often what convinces the jury.

Each criterion in the grid is rated from 1 to 10 by each juror, then weighted according to its importance. Grades are assigned individually, before any deliberation.

Criterion	Weight	What is evaluated	Score (1-10)
Scientific and technical rigor	**20 %**	The foundations of the solution (data, scientific sources, quality of the assumptions), the degree of intellectual rigor, and the credibility of the technical solution. The team also recognizes the limitations of its approach and explains them.	
Appropriate use of AI	**20 %**	AI is essential to the solution and is not simply an add-on. The method is tailored to the problem and the data, and the team clearly explains what the model does.	
Economic viability	**20 %**	The team identifies a user or customer. It also proposes a plausible value proposition, a coherent business model, and a realistic path to adoption.	
Impact and sustainability	**30 %**	Contributing to a more sustainable and resilient food system. The benefits are commensurate with the evidence provided.	
Execution and pitch quality	**10 %**	The quality and solidity of the demonstration, the coherence of the narrative, a team that masters its subject and answers questions solidly.	
Total	**100 %**		

Running order and equipment. The order of presentation will be communicated by email and WhatsApp on Sunday morning. You will present from a shared computer connected to the room's projector. For the live demonstration, please test it before your presentation.

Submitting your project

Deadline: Sunday, November 1st, 9:30 AM, Paris time.

The 8:30 to 9:30 time slot is reserved for finalizing and submitting your work to the Drive.

Required for your project to be evaluated by the jury:

- the **project presentation** (the template will be provided to you) in PDF format, for the jury, containing the link to your code/demo if you have one;
- the **project sheet**, to be completed online, allowing you to explain your project in a short and non-confidential way (it may be shared with external parties by Hack the Fork).

Rules, Intellectual Property and Code of Conduct

Your intellectual property

It belongs to you 100%. The intellectual property created during the hackathon remains the exclusive property of the team members who created it. Neither Hack the Fork, nor AgroParisTech, nor any partners acquire any rights to your work as a result of your participation.

No automatic rights for partners. Some partners may have a right of first look: after the hackathon, they can offer the winning teams the opportunity to discuss a license, a research collaboration, or a partnership. This right does not transfer any ownership to them and does not obligate you in any way: you remain free to accept or decline.

Continuing the project. You are not obligated to continue your project after the hackathon. If Hack the Fork wishes to take over a project you abandon, any transfer or license must be voluntary, written, and validated: nothing is transferred automatically.

Knowledge sharing. Each team provides a short, non-confidential summary of its project, covering the problem addressed, the solution adopted, and the business model. This summary feeds into Hack the Fork's annual report and is one of the submission deliverables.

Competition Integrity

Produced during the event. The solution, code, model, prototype specific to the challenge and the final deck must be developed during the event.

Previous work declared. Desk research, reusable generic libraries and pre-existing resources can be used, under the declaration conditions described above.

Fairness. All teams are subject to the same rules, deadlines, and evaluation criteria, and have the same resources. To maintain this equality, use only the data, tools, infrastructure, and templates authorized by the rules. If you have any doubts, contact Hack the Fork before using them.

Code of Conduct

Hack the Fork aims to be an inclusive, supportive, and collaborative space. No form of discrimination, harassment, intimidation, or disrespectful behavior will be tolerated, whether

towards participants, mentors, jury members, volunteers, or the organizing team. Any violation may result in exclusion from the event.

If you witness or are a victim of such a situation, report it immediately to Inès Mir-Moreaux by email (ines.mir-moreaux@hackthefork.org) or by telephone (+33 6 77 28 65 30).

Every report will be taken seriously.

The prizes awarded to the winners

🥇 **1st place**: 2000$

🥈 **2nd place**: 1000$

🥉 **3rd place**: 500$

Projects selected by the jury are given priority for inclusion in Hack the Fork's pre-incubation program: an opportunity to grow your project well beyond the weekend!

Contacts

Role	Person	Contact
AgroParisTech contacts	Hugo Lecoulant Lucie Avril	+33 6 47 97 48 20 +33 6 10 53 64 94
Hack the Fork contact	**Inès Mir-Moreaux, Head of Local Leaders program**	**+33 6 77 28 65 30**
Other Hack the Fork contact	Morgane Paris, Head of Development	+33 6 44 95 54 05
Participants' channel	Hack the Fork	WhatsApp Link

A question before, during or after the event? Don't hesitate to write to us!

Best,

The Hack the Fork team